

then, alone. Now, do you find the business good, and the investment advantageous?

‘Too much so—too much so.’

‘How can that be?’

‘Because fine things never reach the expected point.’

‘This is infallible, Planchet, and the proof is that I undertake it. It will be for you a tolerably pretty gain, and for me a very interesting stroke. It will be said, “Such was the old age of M. d’Aragnan,” and I shall hold a place in tales and even in history itself, Planchet. I am greedy of honour.’

‘Monsieur,’ cried Planchet, ‘when I think that it is here, in my home, in the midst of my sugar, my prunes, and my cinnamon, that this gigantic project is ripened, my shop seems a palace to me.’

‘Beware, beware, Planchet! If the least report of this escapes, there is the Bastille for both of us. Beware, my friend, for this is a plot we are hatching. M. Monk is the ally of M. Mazarin—beware!’

‘Monsieur, when a man has had the honour to belong to you, he knows nothing of fear; and when he has had the advantage of being bound up in interests with you, he holds his tongue.’

‘Very well; that is more your affair than mine, seeing that in a week I shall be in England.’

‘Depart, monsieur, depart—the sooner the better.’

‘Is the money, then, ready?’

‘It will be to-morrow; to-morrow you shall receive it from my own hands. Will you have gold or silver?’

‘Gold; that is most convenient. But how are we going to arrange this? Let us see.’

‘Oh, good Lord! in the simplest way possible. You shall give me a receipt, that is all.’

‘No, no,’ said D’Aragnan, warmly; ‘we must preserve order in all things.’

‘That is likewise my opinion; but with you, M. d’Aragnan—’

‘And if I should die yonder—if I should be killed by a musket-ball—if I should burst from drinking beer?’

‘Monsieur, I beg you to believe that in that case I should be so much afflicted at your death, that I should not think about the money.’

‘Thank you, Planchet; but no matter. We shall, like two lawyers’ clerks, draw up together an agreement, a sort of act, which may be called a deed of company.’

‘Willingly, monsieur.’

‘I know it is difficult to draw such a thing up, but we can try.’

‘Let us try, then.’ And Planchet went in search of pens, ink, and paper. D’Aragnan took the pen and wrote:—‘Between Messire d’Aragnan, ex-lieutenant of the king’s musketeers, at present residing in the Rue Tiquetonne, Hôtel de la Chevrete; and the Sieur Planchet, grocer, residing in the Rue des Lombards, at the sign of the Pilon d’Or, it has been agreed as follows:—A company, with a capital of forty thousand livres, and formed for the purpose of carrying out an idea conceived by M. d’Aragnan, and the said Planchet approving of it in all points, will place twenty thousand livres in the hands of M. d’Aragnan. He will require neither repayment nor interest before the return of M. d’Aragnan from a journey he is about to take into England. On his part, M. d’Aragnan undertakes it to find twenty thousand livres, which he will join to the twenty thousand already laid down by the Sieur Planchet. He will employ the said sum of forty thousand livres according to his judgment in an undertaking which is described below. On the day when M. d’Aragnan shall have re-established, by whatever means, his majesty King Charles II upon the throne of England, he will pay into the hands of M. Planchet the sum of—’

‘The sum of a hundred and fifty thousand livres,’ said Planchet, innocently, perceiving that D’Aragnan hesitated.

‘Oh, the devil, no!’ said D’Aragnan, ‘the division cannot be made by half; that would not be just.’

‘And yet, monsieur, we each lay down half,’ objected Planchet, timidly.

‘Yes; but listen to this clause, my dear Planchet, and if you do not find it equitable in every respect when it is written, well, we can scratch it out again:—“Nevertheless, as M. d’Aragnan brings to the association, besides his capital of twenty thousand livres, his time, his idea, his industry, and his skin,—things which he appreciates strongly, particularly the last,—M. d’Aragnan will keep, of the three hundred thousand livres, two hundred thousand livres for himself, which will make his share two-thirds.”’

‘Very well,’ said Planchet.

'Is it just?' asked D'Artagnan.

'Perfectly just, monsieur.'

'And you will be contented with a hundred thousand livres?'

'Peste! I think so. A hundred thousand for twenty thousand!'

'And in a month, understand.'

'How, in a month?'

'Yes, I only ask one month.'

'Monsieur,' said Planchet, generously, 'I give you six weeks.'

'Thank you,' replied the musketeer, politely; after which the two partners reperused their deed.

'That is perfect, monsieur,' said Planchet; and the late M. Coquenard, the first husband of Madame la Baronne du Vallon, could not have done it better.'

'Do you find it so? Let us sign it then.' And both affixed their signatures.

'In this fashion,' said D'Artagnan, 'I shall be under obligations to no one.'

'But I shall be under obligations to you,' said Planchet.

'No; for whatever store I set by it, Planchet, I may lose my skin yonder, and you will lose all. A propos—peste!—that makes me think of the principal, an indispensable clause. I shall write it:—"In case of M. d'Artagnan dying in this enterprise, liquidation will be considered made, and the Sieur Planchet will give quitance from that moment to the shade of Messire d'Artagnan for the twenty thousand livres paid by him into the hands of the said company.'"

This last clause made Planchet knit his brows a little, but when he saw the brilliant eye, the muscular hand, the supple and strong back of his associate, he regained his courage, and, without regret, he at once added another stroke to his signature. D'Artagnan did the same. Thus was drawn the first known company contract; perhaps such things have been abused a little since, both in form and principle.

'Now,' said Planchet, pouring out the last glass of Anjou wine for D'Artagnan,—'now go to sleep, my dear master.'

'No,' replied D'Artagnan; 'for the most difficult part now remains to be done, and I will think over that difficult part.'

'Well, Planchet, that is a third plan, of which I had not thought.'

'Do you think it a good one?'

'Yes, certainly; but I think mine better.'

'Let us see yours, then.'

'In the first place, I shall set a ransom on him.'

'Of how much?'

'Peste! a fellow like that must be well worth a hundred thousand crowns.'

'Yes, yes!'

'You see, then—in the first place, a ransom of a hundred thousand crowns.'

'Or else—'

'Or else, what is much better, I deliver him up to King Charles, who, having no longer either a general or an army to fear, nor a diplomatist to trick him, will restore himself, and when once restored, will pay down to me the hundred thousand crowns in question. That is the idea I have formed; what do you say to it, Planchet?'

'Magnificent, monsieur!' cried Planchet, trembling with emotion.

'How did you conceive that idea?'

'It came to me one morning on the banks of the Loire, whilst our beloved king, Louis XIV, was pretending to weep upon the hand of Mademoiselle de Mancini.'

'Monsieur, I declare the idea is sublime. But—'

'Ah! is there a but?'

'Permit me! But this is a little like the skin of that fine bear—you know—that they were about to sell, but which it was necessary to take from the back of the living bear. Now, to take M. Monk, there will be a bit of a scuffle, I should think.'

'No doubt; but as I shall raise an army to—'

'Yes, yes—I understand, parbleu!—a coup-de-main. Yes, then, monsieur, you will triumph, for no one equals you in such sorts of encounters.'

'I certainly am lucky in them,' said D'Artagnan, with a proud simplicity. 'You know that if for this affair I had my dear Athos, my brave Porthos, and my cunning Aramis, the business would be settled; but they are all lost, as it appears, and nobody knows where to find them. I will do it,

‘But M. Cromwell is dead, and his container is now the tomb.’

‘My dear Planchet, I see with pleasure that you have not only become a mathematician, but a philosopher.’

‘Monsieur, in my grocery business I use much printed paper, and that instructs me.’

‘Bravo! You know then, in that case—for you have not learnt mathematics and philosophy without a little history—that after this Cromwell so great, there came one who was very little.’

‘Yes, he was named Richard, and he as done as you have, M. d’Arragnan—he has tendered his resignation.’

‘Very well said—very well! After the great man who is dead, after the little one who tendered his resignation, there came a third. This one is named Monk; he is an able general, considering he has never fought a battle; he is a skilful diplomatist, considering that he never speaks in public, and that having to say “good-day” to a man, he meditates twelve hours, and ends by saying “good night,” which makes people exclaim “miracle!” seeing that it falls out correctly.’

‘That is rather strong,’ said Planchet; ‘but I know another political man who resembles him very much.’

‘M. Mazarin you mean?’

‘Himself.’

‘You are right, Planchet; only M. Mazarin does not aspire to the throne of France; and that changes everything. Do you see? Well, this M. Monk, who has England ready-roasted in his plate, and who is already opening his mouth to swallow it—this M. Monk, who says to the people of Charles II, and to Charles II himself, “Nescio vos” —’

‘I don’t understand English,’ said Planchet.

‘Yes, but I understand it,’ said D’Arragnan. “‘Nescio vos’ means “I do not know you.” This M. Monk, the most important man in England, when he shall have swallowed it—’

‘Well?’ asked Planchet.

‘Well, my friend, I shall go over yonder, and with my forty men I shall carry him off, pack him up, and bring him into France, where two modes of proceeding present themselves to my dazzled eyes.’

‘Oh! and to mine too,’ cried Planchet, transported with enthusiasm. ‘We will put him in a cage and show him for money.’

‘Bah!’ said Planchet; ‘I have such great confidence in you, M. d’Arragnan, that I would not give my hundred thousand livres for ninety thousand livres down.’

‘And devil take me if I don’t think you are right!’ Upon which D’Arragnan took a candle and went up to his bedroom.

‘No, monsieur, I speak what I think, and that is exactly why I say that, in the first pitched battle you fight with your forty men, I am very much afraid —’

‘Therefore I shall fight no pitched battles, my dear Planchet,’ said the Gascon, laughing. ‘We have very fine examples in antiquity of skilful retreats and marches, which consisted in avoiding the enemy instead of attacking them. You should know that, Planchet, you who commanded the Parisians the day on which they ought to have fought against the musketeers, and who so well calculated marches and countermarches, that you never left the Palais Royal.’

Planchet could not help laughing. ‘It is plain,’ replied he, ‘that if your forty men conceal themselves, and are not unskilful, they may hope not to be beaten: but you propose obtaining some result, do you not?’

‘No doubt. This, then, in my opinion, is the plan to be proceeded upon in order quickly to replace his majesty Charles II on his throne.’

‘Good!’ said Planchet, increasing his attention; ‘let us see your plan. But in the first place it seems to me we are forgetting something.’

‘What is that?’

‘We have set aside the nation, which prefers singing merry songs to psalms, and the army, which we will not fight, but the parliament remains, and that seldom sings.’

‘Nor does it fight. How is it, Planchet, that an intelligent man like yourself should take any heed of a set of brawlers who call themselves Rumps and Barebones? The parliament does not trouble me at all, Planchet.’

‘As soon as it ceases to trouble you, monsieur, let us pass on.’

‘Yes, and arrive at the result. You remember Cromwell, Planchet?’

‘I have heard a great deal of talk about him.’

‘He was a rough soldier.’

‘And a terrible eater, moreover.’

‘What do you mean by that?’

‘Why, at one gulp he swallowed all England.’

‘Well, Planchet, the evening before the day on which he swallowed England, if any one had swallowed M. Cromwell?’

‘Oh, monsieur, it is one of the axioms of mathematics that the container must be greater than the contained.’

‘Very well! That is our affair, Planchet.’

‘And then the army.’

‘Good! Do you see anything else?’

‘Why, then the nation.’

‘Is that all?’

‘The nation which consented to the overthrow and death of the late king, the father of this one, and which will not be willing to belie its acts.’

‘Planchet,’ said D’Artagnan, ‘you argue like a cheese! The nation—the nation is tired of these gentlemen who give themselves such barbarous names, and who sing songs to it. Chanting for chanting, my dear Planchet; I have remarked that nations prefer singing a merry chant to the plain chant. Remember the Fronde; what did they sing in those times? Well, those were good times.’

‘Not too good, not too good! I was near being hung in those times.’

‘Well, but you were not.’

‘No.’

‘And you laid the foundations of your fortune in the midst of all those songs?’

‘That is true.’

‘Then you have nothing to say against them.’

‘Well, I return, then, to the army and parliament.’

‘I say that I borrow twenty thousand livres of M. Planchet, and that I put twenty thousand livres of my own to it; and with these forty thousand livres I raise an army.’

Planchet clasped his hands; he saw that D’Artagnan was in earnest, and, in good truth, he believed his master had lost his senses.

‘An army!—ah, monsieur,’ said he, with his most agreeable smile, for fear of irritating the madman, and rendering him furious,—‘an army!—how many?’

‘Of forty men,’ said D’Artagnan.

‘Forty against forty thousand! that is not enough. I know very well that you, M. d’Artagnan, alone, are equal to a thousand men; but where are we to find thirty-nine men equal to you? Or, if we could find them, who would furnish you with money to pay them?’

‘Not bad, Planchet. Ah, the devil! you play the courier.’

Chapter XXI

In which D’Artagnan Prepares to Travel



D’ARTAGNAN reflected to such good purpose during the night that his plan was settled by morning. ‘This is it,’ said he, sitting up in bed, supporting his elbow on his knee, and his chin in his hand;—‘this is it. I shall seek out forty steady, firm men, recruited among people a little compromised, but having habits of discipline. I shall promise them five hundred livres for a month if they return; nothing if they do not return, or half for their kindred. As to food and lodging, that concerns the English, who have cattle in their pastures, bacon in their bacon-racks, fowls in their poultry-yards, and corn in their barns. I will present myself to General Monk with my little body of troops. He will receive me. I shall win his confidence, and take advantage of it, as soon as possible.’

But without going further, D’Artagnan shook his head and interrupted himself. ‘No,’ said he; ‘I should not dare to relate this to Athos; the way is therefore not honourable. I must use violence,’ continued he,—‘very certainly I must, but without compromising my loyalty. With forty men I will traverse the country as a partisan. But if I fall in with, not forty thousand English, as Planchet said, but purely and simply with four hundred, I shall be beaten. Supposing that among my forty warriors there should be found at least ten stupid ones—ten who will allow themselves to be killed one after the other, from mere folly? No; it is, in fact, impossible to find forty men to be depended upon—they do not exist. I must learn how to be contented with thirty. With ten men less I should have the right of avoiding any armed encounter, on account of the small number

of my people; and if the encounter should take place, my chance is better with thirty men than forty. Besides, I should save five thousand francs; that is to say, the eighth of my capital; that is worth the trial. This being so, I should have thirty men. I shall divide them into three bands,—we will spread ourselves about over the country, with an injunction to reunite at a given moment; in this fashion, ten by ten, we should excite no suspicion—we should pass unperceived. Yes, yes, thirty—that is a magic number. There are three tens—three, that divine number! And then, truly, a company of thirty men, when all together, will look rather imposing. Ah! stupid wretch that I am! continued D'Artagnan, 'I want thirty horses. That is ruinous. Where the devil was my head when I forgot the horses? We cannot, however, think of striking such a blow without horses. Well, so be it, that sacrifice must be made; we can get the horses in the country—they are not bad, besides. But I forgot—peste! Three bands—that necessitates three leaders; there is the difficulty. Of the three commanders I have already one—that is myself;—yes, but the two others will of themselves cost almost as much money as all the rest of the troop. No; positively I must have but one lieutenant. In that case, then, I should reduce my troop to twenty men. I know very well that twenty men is but very little; but since with thirty I was determined not to seek to come to blows, I should do so more carefully still with twenty. Twenty—that is a round number; that, besides, reduces the number of the horses by ten, which is a consideration; and then, with a good lieutenant—Mordieux! what things patience and calculation are! Was I not going to embark with forty men, and I have now reduced them to twenty for an equal success? Ten thousand livres saved at one stroke, and more safety; that is well! Now, then, let us see; we have nothing to do but to find this lieutenant—let him be found, then; and after—That is not so easy; he must be brave and good, a second myself. Yes, but a lieutenant must have my secret, and as that secret is worth a million, and I shall only pay my man a thousand livres, fifteen hundred at the most, my man will sell the secret to Monk. Mordieux! no lieutenant. Besides, this man, were he as mute as a disciple of Pythagoras,—this man would be sure to have in the troop some favourite soldier, whom he would make his sergent; the sergent would penetrate the secret of the lieutenant, in case the latter should be honest and unwilling to sell it. Then the sergent,

"Poor little seed of a king," said I to myself, and really I was affected, Planchet, which leads me to think I am entering upon a foolish business. And that is why I wished to consult you, my friend."

Planchet coloured with pleasure and pride.

"Poor little seed of a king! I will pick you up and cast you into good ground."

'Good God!' said Planchet, looking earnestly at his old master, as if in doubt as to the state of his reason.

'Well, what is it?' said D'Artagnan; 'who hurts you?'

'Me! nothing, monsieur.'

'You said, "Good God!"'

'Did I?'

'I am sure you did. Can you already understand?'

'I confess, M. d'Artagnan, that I am afraid—'

'To understand?'

'Yes.'

'To understand that I wish to replace upon his throne this King Charles II, who has no throne? Is that it?'

Planchet made a prodigious bound in his chair. 'Ah, ah!' said he, in evident terror, 'that is what you call a restoration!'

'Yes, Planchet; is it not the proper term for it?'

'Oh, no doubt, no doubt! But have you reflected seriously?'

'Upon what?'

'Upon what is going on yonder.'

'Where?'

'In England.'

'And what is that? Let us see, Planchet.'

'In the first place, monsieur, I ask you pardon for meddling in these things, which have nothing to do with my trade; but since it is an affair that you propose to me—for you are proposing an affair, are you not?—'

'A superb one, Planchet.'

'But as it is business you propose to me, I have the right to discuss it.'

'Discuss it, Planchet; out of discussion is born light.'

'Well, then, since I have monsieur's permission, I will tell him that there is yonder, in the first place, the parliament.'

'Well, next?'

I. As to the eldest, I have the honour of knowing him by name, but not personally.’

‘That is exactly the point, Planchet, we must come to: it is to this eldest son, formerly called the Prince of Wales, and who is now styled Charles II, king of England.’

‘A king without a kingdom, monsieur,’ replied Planchet, sententiously.

‘Yes, Planchet, and you may add an unfortunate prince, more unfortunate than the poorest man of the people lost in the worst quarter of Paris.’

Planchet made a gesture full of that sort of compassion which we grant to strangers with whom we think we can never possibly find ourselves in contact. Besides, he did not see in this politico-sentimental operation any sign of the commercial idea of M. d’Aragnan, and it was in this idea that D’Aragnan, who was, from habit, pretty well acquainted with men and things, had principally interested Planchet.

‘I am come to our business. This young Prince of Wales, a king without a kingdom, as you have so well said, Planchet, has interested me. I, D’Aragnan, have seen him begging assistance of Mazarin, who is a miser, and the aid of Louis, who is a child, and it appeared to me, who am acquainted with such things, that in the intelligent eye of the fallen king, in the nobility of his whole person, a nobility apparent above all his miseries, I could discern the stuff of a man and the heart of a king.’

Planchet tacitly approved of all this; but it did not at all, in his eyes at least, throw any light upon D’Aragnan’s idea. The latter continued: ‘This, then, is the reasoning which I made with myself. Listen attentively, Planchet, for we are coming to the conclusion.’

‘I am listening.’

‘Kings are not so thickly sown upon the earth, that people can find them whenever they want them. Now, this king without a kingdom is, in my opinion, a grain of seed which will blossom in some season or other, provided a skilful, discreet, and vigorous hand sow it duly and truly, selecting soil, sky, and time.’

Planchet still approved by a nod of his head, which showed that he did not perfectly comprehend all that was said.

less honest and less ambitious, will give up the whole for fifty thousand livres. Come, come! that is impossible. The lieutenant is impossible. But then I must have no fractions; I cannot divide my troop in two, and act upon two points, at once, without another self, who—But what is the use of acting upon two points, as we have only one man to take? What can be the use of weakening a corps by placing the right here, and the left there? A single corps—Mordoux! a single one, and that commanded by D’Aragnan. Very well. But twenty men marching in one band are suspected by everybody; twenty horsemen must not be seen marching together, or a company will be detached against them and the password will be required; the which company, upon seeing them embarrassed to give it, would shoot M. d’Aragnan and his men like so many rabbits. I reduce myself then to ten men; in this fashion I shall act simply and with unity; I shall be forced to be prudent, which is half the success in an affair of the kind I am undertaking; a greater number might, perhaps, have drawn me into some folly. Ten horses are not many, either, to buy or take. A capital idea; what tranquillity it infuses into my mind! no more suspicions—no passwords—no more dangers! Ten men, they are valets or clerks. Ten men, leading ten horses laden with merchandise of whatever kind, are tolerated, well received everywhere. Ten men travel on account of the house of Planchet & Co., of France,—nothing can be said against that. These ten men, clothed like manufacturers, have a good cutlass or a good musket at their saddle-bow, and a good pistol in the holster. They never allow themselves to be uneasy, because they have no evil designs. They are, perhaps, in truth, a little disposed to be smugglers, but what harm is in that? Smuggling is not, like polygamy, a hanging offence. The worst that can happen to us is the confiscation of our merchandise. Our merchandise confiscated—a fine affair that! Come, come! it is a superb plan. Ten men only—ten men, whom I will engage for my service; ten men who shall be as resolute as forty, who would cost me four times as much, and to whom, for greater security, I will never open my mouth as to my designs, and to whom I shall only say “My friends, there is a blow to be struck.” Things being after this fashion, Satan will be very malicious if he plays me one of his tricks. Fifteen thousand livres saved—that’s superb—out of twenty!’

Thus fortified by his labourious calculations, D'Artagnan stopped at this plan, and determined to change nothing in it. He had already on a list furnished by his inexhaustible memory, ten men illustrious amongst the seekers of adventure, ill-treated by fortune, and not on good terms with justice. Upon this D'Artagnan rose, and instantly set off on the search, telling Planchet not to expect him to breakfast, and perhaps not to dinner. A day and a half spent in rummaging amongst certain dens of Paris sufficed for his recruiting; and, without allowing his adventurers to communicate with each other, he had picked up and got together, in less than thirty hours, a charming collection of ill-looking faces, speaking a French less pure than the English they were about to attempt. These men were, for the most part, guards, whose merit D'Artagnan had had an opportunity of appreciating in various encounters, whom drunkenness, unlucky sword-thrusts, unexpected winnings at play, or the economical reforms of Mazarin, had forced to seek shade and solitude, those two great consolars of irritated and chafing spirits. They bore upon their countenances and in their vestments the traces of the heartaches they had undergone. Some had their visages scarred,—all had their clothes in rags. D'Artagnan comforted the most needy of these brotherly miseries by a prudent distribution of the crowns of the company; then, having taken care that these crowns should be employed in the physical improvement of the troop, he appointed a trysting place in the north of France, between Bergues and Saint Omer. Six days were allowed as the utmost term, and D'Artagnan was sufficiently acquainted with the good-will, the good-humour, and the relative probity of these illustrious recruits, to be certain that not one of them would fail in his appointment. These orders given, this rendezvous fixed, he went to bid farewell to Planchet, who asked news of his army. D'Artagnan did not think it proper to inform him of the reduction he had made in his personnel. He feared that the confidence of his associate would be abated by such an avowal. Planchet was delighted to learn that the army was levied, and that he (Planchet) found himself a kind of half king, who from his throne-counter kept in pay a body of troops destined to make war against perfidious Albion, that enemy of all true French hearts. Planchet paid down in double louis, twenty thousand livres to D'Artagnan, on the part of himself (Planchet), and twenty thousand livres, still in double louis, in account with D'Artagnan.

Chapter XX

Of the Society which was Formed in the Rue des Lombards



AFTER a moment's silence, in which D'Artagnan appeared to be collecting, not one idea but all his ideas,—‘It cannot be, my dear Planchet,’ said he, ‘that you have not heard of his majesty Charles I of England?’

‘Alas! yes, monsieur, since you left France in order to assist him, and that, in spite of that assistance, he fell, and was near dragging you down in his fall.’

‘Exactly so; I see you have a good memory, Planchet.’

‘Peste! the astonishing thing would be, if I could have lost that memory, however bad it might have been. When one has heard Grimaud, who, you know, is not given to talking, relate how the head of King Charles fell, how you sailed the half of a night in a scuttled vessel, and saw floating on the water that good M. Mordaunt with a certain gold-hafted dagger buried in his breast, one is not very likely to forget such things.’

‘And yet there are people who forget them, Planchet.’

‘Yes, such as have not seen them, or have not heard Grimaud relate them.’

‘Well, it is all the better that you recollect all that; I shall only have to remind you of one thing, and that is that Charles I had a son.’

‘Without contradicting you, monsieur, he had two,’ said Planchet; ‘for I saw the second one in Paris, M. le Duke of York, one day, as he was going to the Palais Royal, and I was told that he was not the eldest son of Charles

D'Artagnan placed each of the twenty thousand francs in a bag, and weighing a bag in each hand,—‘This money is very embarrassing, my dear Planchet,’ said he. ‘Do you know this weighs thirty pounds?’

‘Bah! your horse will carry that like a feather.’

D'Artagnan shook his head. ‘Don’t tell me such things, Planchet: a horse overloaded with thirty pounds, in addition to the rider and his portmanteau, cannot cross a river so easily—cannot leap over a wall or ditch so lightly; and the horse failing, the horseman falls. It is true that you, Planchet, who have served in the infantry, may not be aware of all that.’

‘Then what is to be done, monsieur?’ said Planchet, greatly embarrassed.

‘Listen to me,’ said D'Artagnan. ‘I will pay my army on its return home. Keep my half of twenty thousand livres, which you can use during that time.’

‘And my half?’ said Planchet.

‘I shall take that with me.’

‘Your confidence does me honour,’ said Planchet: ‘but supposing you should not return?’

‘That is possible, though not very probable. Then, Planchet, in case I should not return—give me a pen; I will make my will.’ D'Artagnan took a pen and some paper, and wrote upon a plain sheet,—

I, D'Artagnan, possess twenty thousand livres, laid up
cent per cent during thirty years that I have been in the ser-
vice of his majesty the king of France. I leave five thousand to
Athos, five thousand to Porthos, and five thousand to Ar-
mis, that they may give the said sums in my name and their
own to my young friend Raoul, Vicomte de Bragelonne. I
give the remaining five thousand to Planchet, that he may
distribute the fifteen thousand with less regret among my
friends. With which purpose I sign these presents.

D'ARTAGNAN.

Planchet appeared very curious to know what D'Artagnan had written. 'Here,' said the musketeer, 'read it.'

On reading the last lines the tears came into Planchet's eyes. 'You think, then, that I would not have given the money without that? Then I will have none of your five thousand francs.'

D'Artagnan smiled. 'Accept it, accept it, Planchet; and in that way you will only lose fifteen thousand francs instead of twenty thousand, and you will not be tempted to disregard the signature of your master and friend, by losing nothing at all.'

How well that dear Monsieur d'Artagnan knew the hearts of men and grocers! They who have pronounced Don Quixote mad because he rode out to the conquest of an empire with nobody but Sancho his squire, and they who have pronounced Sancho mad because he accompanied his master in his attempt to conquer the said empire,—they certainly will have no hesitation in extending the same judgment to D'Artagnan and Planchet. And yet the first passed for one of the most subtle spirits among the astute spirits of the court of France. As to the second, he had acquired by good right the reputation of having one of the longest heads among the grocers of the Rue des Lombards; consequently of Paris, and consequently of France. Now, to consider these two men from the point of view from which you would consider other men, and the means by the aid of which they contemplated to restore a monarch to his throne, compared with other means, the shallowest brains of the country where brains are most shallow must have revolted against the presumptuous madness of the lieutenant and the stupidity of his associate. Fortunately, D'Artagnan was not a man to listen to the idle talk of those around him, or to the comments that were made on himself. He had adopted the motto, 'Act well, and let people talk.' Planchet, on his part had adopted this, 'Act and say nothing.' It resulted from this, that, according to the custom of all superior geniuses, these two men flattered themselves, intrapectus, with being in the right against all who found fault with them.

As a beginning, D'Artagnan set out in the finest of possible weather, without a cloud in the heavens—without a cloud on his mind, joyous and strong, calm and decided, great in his resolution, and consequently carrying with him a tenfold dose of that potent fluid which the shocks of mind cause to spring from the nerves, and which procure for the human

'Planchet, it is a restoration.'

'Of monuments?'

'Yes, of monuments; we shall restore Whitehall.'

'That is important. And in a month, you think?'

'I shall undertake it.'

'That concerns you, monsieur, and when once you are engaged—'

'Yes, that concerns me. I know what I am about; nevertheless, I will freely consult with you.'

'You do me great honour, but I know very little about architecture.'

'Planchet, you are wrong; you are an excellent architect, quite as good as I am, for the case in question.'

'Thanks, monsieur. But your old friends of the musketeers?'

'I have been, I confess, tempted to speak of the thing to those gentlemen, but they are all absent from their houses. It is vexatious, for I know none more bold or able.'

'Ah! then it appears there will be an opposition, and the enterprise will be disputed?'

'Oh, yes, Planchet, yes.'

'I burn to know the details, monsieur.'

'Here they are, Planchet—close all the doors tight.'

'Yes, monsieur.' And Planchet double-locked them.

'That is well; now draw near.' Planchet obeyed.

'And open the window, because the noise of the passers-by and the carts will deafen all who might hear us.' Planchet opened the window as desired, and the gust of tumult which filled the chamber with cries, wheels, barking, and steps deafened D'Artagnan himself, as he had wished. He then swallowed a glass of white wine, and began in these terms: 'Planchet, I have an idea.'

'Ah! monsieur, I recognize you so well in that,' replied Planchet, panting with emotion.